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Part I: The Grey Mountains

THE WIND CAME DOWN FROM THE GREY MOUNTAINS CARRYING THE SMELL OF BURNT CEDAR AND SOMETHING OLDER—SOMETHING THAT HAD NO NAME IN THE COMMON TONGUE, BUT WHICH EVERY SOLDIER RECOGNISED IN THE HOLLOW OF THEIR RIBS. Aelindra tightened the strap of her vambrace and said nothing.

Below, the valley curved like a wound in the earth, its floor dark with the remnants of what had been three villages not a fortnight past. The smoke still rose in thin, patient threads, as though the ground itself had not yet decided whether to forgive. She counted the fires. Seven. No—eight, if the far glow past the treeline was theirs and not some shepherd's accident.

Eight fires meant a column, not a raid. A column meant orders. Orders meant someone, somewhere, had decided this particular valley was worth the cost of making it into a memory.



Aelindra had spent seventeen years learning the difference between decisions made in rooms and decisions that lived in the soil